

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, July 21, 2015

The meeting convened at 7:00 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Thomas Cleary, Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Joseph Pipczynski, Chevy Seney, Celeste Whiting.

Also present: Joe Boudreau, Town Accountant; Chris Norris, Fire Chief for part of meeting.

1. Approved minutes of 6/16/15. Vote 9-0-0.
Approved minutes of 7/14/15. Vote 9-0-0.
2. Reviewed Finance Committee members contact information sheet.
3. No correspondence.
4. FY15 Budget Closeout—Joe Boudreau reviewed the FY15 expense report with regard to year-end closing. We will have approximately \$65,000 to go to next year's Free Cash certification.
5. FY 16—When we prepared the budget for Town Meeting, the budget was unbalanced by \$18,000. It is now unbalanced by \$33,000. This is due to the almost-final cherry sheets reporting that Westhampton will receive less in charter school reimbursements than originally projected. We need to balance this budget by December 1 since the town bills our taxes quarterly. We also need to check with the assessors to see if we can get more solid numbers for New Growth by then.

In addition to the operating budget shortfall, we have a matching grant shortfall for the new tanker truck. At the time of the grant application, the tanker truck was projected to cost \$30,000 less than it does now. We must come up with the difference.

We discussed options to solve the budget shortfall and the grant shortfall.

Options discussed were:

- Debt exclusion vote
- Override
- Free Cash

- Cut budget for FY16 and have another town meeting to approve
- Use money from the stabilization fund (\$25,000)

Joe reports that if we do a debt exclusion for \$60,000 to borrow the money for the truck and to make up the \$33,000 we need to balance the budget, then we could rescind the \$30,000 we have already voted to appropriate from the operating budget for the tanker truck. We would need to have a special town meeting to authorize the \$60,000 debt.

We discussed the timeframe for this action as it was reported that once the grant is officially awarded, we have 30-days to accept the grant. There was some confusion about how soon we need to vote to appropriate the money. Chris Norris arrived and clarified that we can accept the grant and vote to appropriate the additional \$30,000 at a later day (most likely within the year).

We also learned at this time that \$23,000 will be returned from the state to Westhampton as Chapter 90 money for the highway department.

6. New Business—There is a Safety Complex Study Committee forming. It was requested that a FinCom member sit on that committee. Joe Pipczynski volunteered to serve on that committee. Thank you, Joe.

7. Cherry Sheets—We reviewed the cherry sheets. Joe Boudreau noted that the numbers could still change. He also noted that we appropriated \$356,000 for vocational tuition. The most recent cherry sheet tells us that we would be liable for \$367,084 if all students that have applied attend.

8. Strategies to address continued capital funds shortfall and balanced budget shortfalls—Ellice handed out a document with thoughts about steps for more strategic planning with the goal of turning the FinCom from a reactive committee to a proactive, solutions-oriented committee. Our homework is to review the document, think about the next steps and share them at the next FinCom meeting.

9. Other issues—We use too much paper. From now on we will email minutes before the meeting so that they can be reviewed ahead of time and save paper.

10. Personnel Changes—We have had a change in the Treasurer and Tax Collector positions. As a result of the personnel changes, we are required to have a tax collector audit completed. It is already underway. It will cost approximately \$5000. We discuss how to pay this unexpected bill. We determined that it may be possible to use the Town Audit account money, but that would require a Town Meeting to appropriate. Or we could use money from the reserve fund and then reappropriate the money for the reserve fund at a later date at town meeting.

11. Next meeting will discuss fiscal health and future planning.

12. Joe Boudreau volunteered to conduct a budget workshop at some point to the FinCom and Selectboard.

13. Next Meeting—Tuesday, August 4 at 7:00 pm

The meeting adjourned at 9:00 pm.

Respectfully Submitted
by Mary Cleary